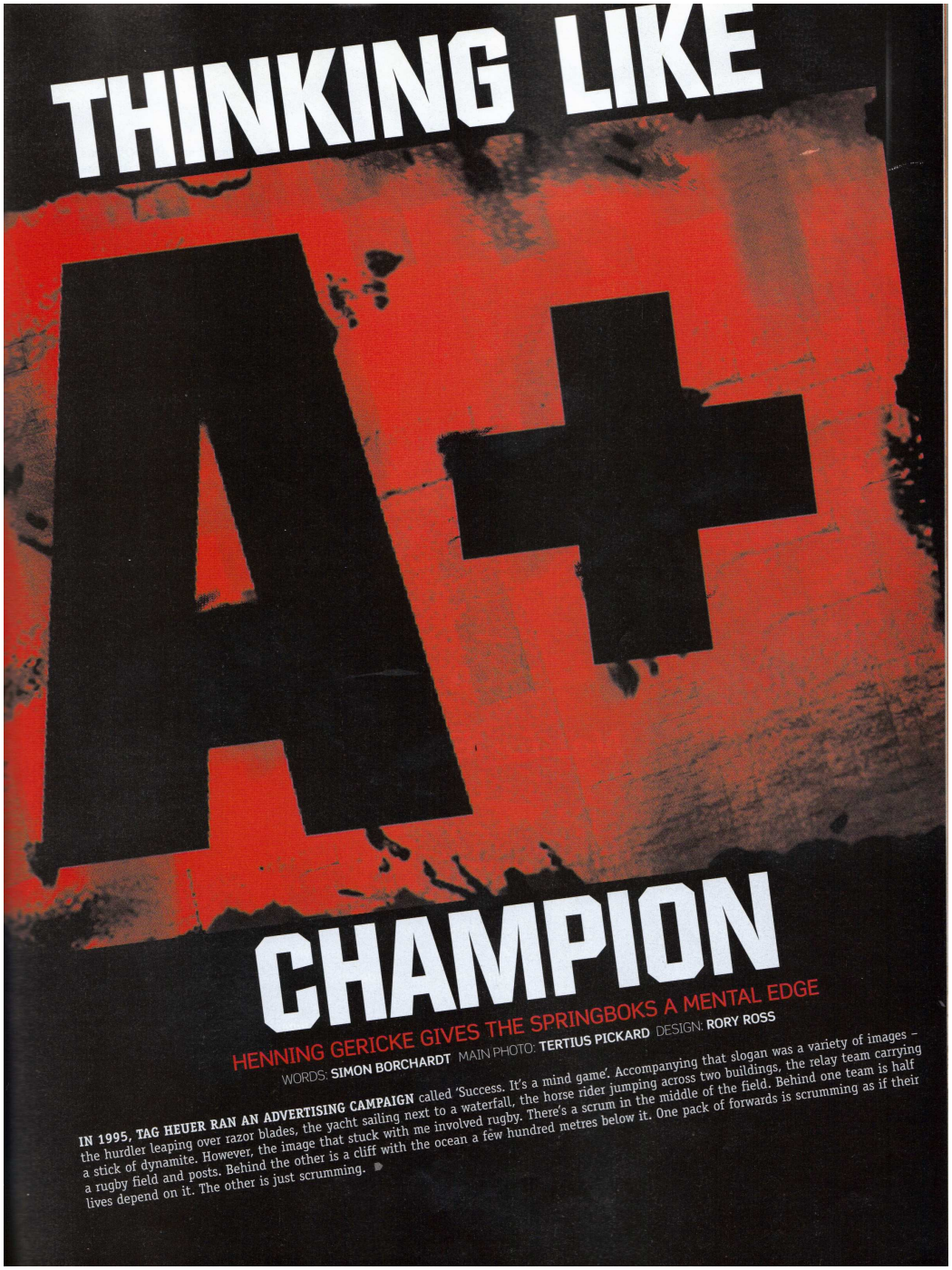
THINKING LIKE A CHAMPION:



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HENNING GERICKE GIVES THE SPRINGBOKS A MENTAL EDGE

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IN 1995, TAG HEUER RAN AN ADVERTISING CAMPAIGN called 'Success. It's a mind game'. Accompanying that slogan was a variety of images – the hurdler leaping over razor blades, the yacht sailing next to a waterfall, the horse rider jumping across two buildings, the relay team carrying a stick of dynamite. However, the image that stuck with me involved rugby. There's a scrum in the middle of the field. Behind one team is half a rugby field and posts. Behind the other is a cliff with the ocean a few hundred metres below it. One pack of forwards is scrumming as if their lives depend on it. The other is just scrumming.

Reference:

Borchart, S. (2007). THINKING LIKE A+ CHAMPION. SA Rugby Magazine (2007)

Henning Gericke, the Springboks mental and speed coach, firmly believes success is a mind game. He has a doctorate in psychology and has broken new ground in the field of mental coaching. When he was an elite athlete, he ran 10 sub-four-minute miles – a feat that requires great physical and mental strength.

When Gericke joined the Boks in 2004, the beginning of the Jake White era, he found a group of players still carrying mental scars from the Rudolf Straeuli regime. The first thing he did to repair the damage was to create a family environment, where players care for each other. Unlike Straeuli, he also got the players' families involved wherever possible.

Gericke then set about restoring the Boks' focus on the game. Over the last four years, he has held weekly sessions with the squad and regularly meets each player on an individual basis.

'In our weekly group sessions, I look at the mental challenges that we face in the upcoming Test,' he tells *SA Rugby* magazine. 'For example, we may need to be aggressive but relaxed enough to make good decisions on the field. We may have a poor record at the stadium at which we're going to play and need to make that negative mindset positive.

'The individual sessions are equally important,' he adds. 'Every player is different mentally, so I find out what motivates each one. Where does he get his inner strength? Where does he get his calmness? Where does he get his focus? What's the best mental frame I can put him in?'

Gericke's approach to mental training varies according to the needs of the player. 'Someone like JP [Pietersen] needs to feel confident and needs constant encouragement to help build and maintain that confidence,' he says. 'Despite playing 70-plus Tests, Os [du Randt] always feels the need to prove himself and show his team-mates he deserves to be in the squad. Os needs to set goals. He always wants to challenge himself and get better. Butch [James], on the other hand, plays by the three Cs – cool, calm and confident. When he was too aggressive in the past, his decision-making suffered, so the three Cs remind him of the way he wants to play. Basically, you have to find the right mental triggers to get the player into the zone that works for him.'

Few of us who admit being average sportsmen have ever been in the zone. Perhaps we entered it briefly by scoring a try or hitting a six at school or club level, but we haven't stayed there for long. The best in the business not only play in the zone for lengthy periods, they know how to get there regularly.

'The zone is a state of being when things just happen for a player,' explains Gericke. 'You feel you're always in the right place at the right time. You make the right decisions. You don't overanalyse your game. When you are in the zone, the mind trusts the body and the body trusts the mind. You enjoy the here and now, you don't worry about the outcome. The zone is a state of mind where you're calm, relaxed and focused.'

One Springbok who has successfully entered the zone this season is Frans Steyn. Having taken massive flak for missing a conversion that would have won the Sharks the Super 14 final and then failing to find touch after the hooter, the 20-year-old made amends against the Wallabies at Newlands. Steyn came off the bench in the final quarter when the Boks were trailing 19-16. The replacement winger levelled the scores with an ambitious drop goal from the right-hand touchline and then won the game with another from an easier position a few minutes from full time. When asked afterwards what had gone through his mind Steyn said, 'Er, nothing. I trusted my instincts.'

'Frans's answer sums up what it's like to be in the zone,' Gericke says. 'People probably weren't expecting a lot from him that day, because he was a substitute, so he could just come on and play his natural game. Another Bok who I always tell to trust his instincts is André Pretorius. André has a kicking routine that works for him, so I try not to get too involved. Before a game, I'll walk up to him and remind him to back himself on the field. That's all I need to say.'

It's the 2007 World Cup final between the Boks and All Blacks at Stade de France. A Dan Carter penalty has just put New Zealand into a one-point lead with two minutes to go. The Bok restart goes deep and bounces into touch after brushing a Kiwi hand. South Africa have one last chance to win the game, and the Webb Ellis Cup, with a line-out 5m from the opposition tryline. This next passage of play will determine whether the Boks spend the next four years as world champions or wondering what might have been. The pressure is suffocating. Or is it?

'My job is to prepare the players for a situation like that,' says Gericke. 'Obviously, this team has never trailed by a point in a World Cup final before, so we can't draw on previous experience. Instead, we create "what if?" scenarios for the players. What if we are in a situation like the one you've just described? Well, we'd want to keep focused and stick to the basics ... do what we'd do in any other Test match. If that means throwing the ball to Bakkies [Botha], setting up the driving maul and going for the pushover try, then so be it. If that means trying to create space and time for a drop goal attempt, then that's what must be done.'

Gericke says the secret to winning those close battles is in keeping composure. 'We have trigger words to help the Boks achieve this. John [Smit], for example, will yell out a word that will put everybody in the same frame of mind. One word can tell the team to slow the pace down, stick to the basics, focus on the small things, stay cool etc ... It's a case of shared thinking in that every player will know what to do.

'We've been involved in a few close games since 2004. Some we've won, others we've lost, but we've learnt a lot from them all. To win those games you need decision-makers, players in key positions – hooker, flyhalf, fullback etc – who can handle the pressure. We have those players.'



Gericke insists the Boks would not choke in a World Cup final.

PHOTO: TERTIUS PICKARD/GALLO IMAGES

Chokers. It's a word that sticks to sports teams and individuals who crack under pressure and lose matches they should have won. In the 1993 Wimbledon women's singles final, Jana Novotna led Steffi Graf 4-1 in the deciding third set and was up 40-15 on her serve. Then the Czechoslovakian lost her nerve, missing simple shots, including an overhead smash that hit the back tarp. Graf won the next five games and a shattered Novotna cried on the Duchess of Kent's shoulder.

In the 1999 Cricket World Cup semi-finals, South Africa needed one run off four balls with one wicket in hand. Lance Klusener, whose big hitting had brought the Proteas back from the dead, called for a quick single. Allan Donald, at the other end, hesitated, dropped his bat and was run out. The match was tied but Australia progressed to the final on a superior run rate.

As far as the Rugby World Cup is concerned, the All Blacks were the best team in 1995 but lost to the Boks in the final. They were red-hot favourites in 1999 but self-imploded against France in the semi-finals. It was a similar case in 2003, when they gifted the Wallabies an intercept try in the semi-finals and went on to lose a match most expected them to win quite comfortably.

'Choking does happen in sport,' says Gericke. 'It comes from high and sometimes unrealistic expectations. The All Blacks, for example, are under huge pressure to win the World Cup this year. Their fans demand it. Their media demand it. Hell, the whole country demands it.'

When delving into the choking phenomenon, Gericke uses an example not listed above. 'I believe a team that is mentally strong will not allow choking to happen. They will take control of the situation. Look at our cricket team at the World Cup this year. A lot of people had a lot to say about them, and they responded by changing their tactics for the semi-final against Australia. They came out attacking Australia's bowlers, taking crazy risks, and lost five wickets for 27 runs. That shows me they weren't in control of what they wanted to do.'

Gericke insists the Boks will not allow outside pressure to change their approach to the game. 'We won't choke at the World Cup because we have a core of experienced players and good, strong leadership. I know our guys will keep their cool, stay focused and do what has worked for them in the past.'

Some players have big-match temperament, some don't. Some players thrive under pressure, some don't.

'Players who have BMT have often been in a pressurised situation before and been successful,' says Gericke. 'That builds confidence and they believe they'll be able to succeed again if they find themselves in a similar situation. Other players have crumbled under the pressure, so when they're under pressure again, they doubt themselves and have negative thoughts. And if your mind's not right, you won't have BMT.'

Whereas Gericke insists everyone who reaches Bok level has BMT, he admits he does have to calm a player down every now and then. 'It's all about anxiety and confidence; you need to get the balance right. If you worry too much, your confidence will go down, but if you don't worry at all and you're overconfident, then you're asking for trouble.

'Self-awareness is crucial in order to have BMT. You must be aware of what works for you. If you can do that, you will be in control of all situations. There will be times when you make mistakes, and you have to know how to calm yourself down and refocus.'

Gericke constantly reminds his players that the way they think about themselves affects how they play.

'We talk about the Law of Attraction, which states you attract what you think. People who think like champions are successful. People often aim not to fail instead of aiming to succeed. They've always been told "Don't do this, don't do that", so they can't be creative and true to themselves. The Springboks are going to think like champions at the World Cup and play like champions. I can promise you that.'

We're nearing the end of our interview when Jake White walks past looking worried. I ask Gericke whether he ever has mental-training sessions with the Bok coach, who is often under more pressure than his players.

'Jake does take strain, so we'll meet two or three times a week and chat about things,' he says. 'It's very informal, perhaps over a couple of drinks. I try to focus his thoughts, and we'll discuss the pressure he's under. He'll go to gym in the morning, so he has his way of dealing with it, and every now and then I'll give him something to read that I think may help him. Sometimes he'll ask me about a player and I'll tell him what I think.

'Mentally, Jake is incredibly focused on winning the World Cup. He knows he's entering the final straight of his Bok coaching career and he can't be sacked.'

Gericke also has a special relationship with the captain. 'John will come up to me and discuss what the team needs and what certain individuals need, so I'm always aware of the vibe in the squad. For example, we arranged a team-building exercise in Durban before the World Cup where the players went on a 10km walk. Along the route there were places to stop and at each place they had to discuss a previous Bok World Cup campaign. At the end of the walk, they arrived at John's house, where every player had a person waiting for them who is an important part of their life. The team gets extra energy from things like that.'

I shake hands with Gericke and am walking away when he calls me back. 'You know, I honestly believe we can win the World Cup. The players believe it too.' From the look in his eyes, I can see there's no doubt in his mind.



Os du Randt always feels the need to prove himself.

PHOTO: LEE WARREN/GALLO IMAGES